

Radiance: Sampo

A Concise Literary-Philosophical Research Note on Abundance and Participation

Author and artistic researcher: Nikolai Kostyshev / Ashraellen

Project: Radiance / Сияние

Form: literary-philosophical artistic research through fiction

Status: WORKING DRAFT v1 / English transcreation from Russian source

Created: 2026-06-28

Updated: 2026-06-28

Source: Projects/Radiance/Research/Sampo/Sampo_Concise_Research_Note_RU.md

This is the English transcreation of the Russian source note for Radiance / Сияние — Book I: Sampo / Книга I. Сампо.

This version is intended as a Kone-facing / institution-facing companion text. It is not a literal translation. It preserves the conceptual structure and inner movement of the Russian source while adapting the language for English-language artistic-research contexts.

Purpose of this note

This note does not replace the novel, and it should not become the primary body of the project.

Book I: Sampo already exists as a literary work. It does not need to be reduced to a scheme, explained to exhaustion, or replaced by a theoretical summary. The novel was written as a living form of inquiry: through people, a house, bread, water, forest, hunger, shame, care, error, participation and recognition.

Yet the novel also needs a concise map beside it. Not in order to simplify the work, but to show that behind its literary form there is not accidental fantasy, decorative northern mythology or a retelling of an epic, but a structured literary-philosophical inquiry.

The working formula of this note is:

The novel is the living artistic body of the research.

The concise note is the map / key / skeleton of what the novel investigates.

Therefore this text should be read not as a treatise instead of the novel, but as a brief companion to the internal research that the novel has already carried out through literary means.

1. What is Sampo?

In this work, Sampo is not treated as a lost mythological object, nor as a device to be reconstructed, explained or possessed.

Sampo is approached as a literary-philosophical motif through which Book I investigates abundance, ownership, hunger, participation and recognition.

On the surface, Sampo can be imagined as a mythic mill, a miraculous source of prosperity, a machine of abundance, or an object that can be found, received, taken, hidden, guarded or held. This is also how the human being often imagines the source of life: as something that can be extracted from the world, placed in front of oneself, and called one's own.

But within the logic of Radiance, Sampo cannot be reduced to a thing. It is not an object lying somewhere in a forest, in a house, in the earth, or in someone else's hands. Sampo is an image

of a human error of perception. The human being searches for the source of abundance as a separate object while already standing inside the living order that feeds him.

This gives rise to the inner formula of the book:

They searched for Sampo as a machine.
They lived inside Sampo as Creation.
They wanted provision without participation.

In the novel, Sampo moves through several stages.

At first, it is a word. Then a rumor. Then pressure. Then the desire to find. Then the hope for a thing. Then the dream of a machine. Then a disappointment, because the living does not allow itself to be taken into the hand in the way a human being wants to take a mechanism. Only near the end does recognition become possible: Sampo did not stand in the house. The house stood inside it.

This recognition is not pronounced as a thesis. It cannot be properly understood if it is merely written down as a definition. For that reason, the novel does not explain Sampo completely. It brings the reader to the point where the old question no longer works.

The old question was:

Where is Sampo?

But the new question can no longer be asked in that form, because Sampo is no longer a point on a map. It is the living system inside which the human being stands, eats, breathes, waits, makes mistakes, shares, demands, receives, damages and learns to participate.

2. The central research question

The central question of Book I can be stated simply:

Why does the human being search for a machine of abundance while standing inside a living world that already feeds him?

This question is not only about myth. It is not only about an ancient story. It concerns the human way of seeing the world.

The human being often fails to recognize the source when the source has not been separated from life. It is easier to believe in an object, a device, a secret place, a formula, a recipe, a map, a right of ownership or a technology than in a living network of relations, conditions and participation. The human being wants the result without remaining connected to what makes the result possible.

He wants bread without earth. Warmth without fire. A house without exchange with the world. Plenty without measure. Fruit without time. Life without dependence on the living.

In this sense, Sampo becomes more than a mythological image of abundance. It becomes a mirror of a human error. The human being wants to pull the source out of the world, place it before himself, and make it his own. Yet a source that nourishes life cannot be fully removed from the living order. When it is extracted, it ceases to be what it was.

The novel does not treat the thirst for life itself as guilt. Hunger is not condemned. The desire for food, warmth, shelter, reserve and peace is not presented as a sin. The error begins elsewhere: where the human being wants provision without participation.

Key formula:

The error is not hunger itself, but the desire for provision without participation.

From this, the inner drama of Sampo grows. The guests do not arrive as pupils, followers, or participants in a spiritual retreat. They arrive as people: each with fatigue, defenses,

intelligence, awkwardness, memory, need and inner hunger. The house, bread, water, forest, weather and simple acts gradually begin to disturb their habit of treating the living as an object. This is the research task of the novel: not to prove an idea, but to lead the reader through forms of experience in which the idea becomes visible.

3. Why literary form, not theory?

Sampo cannot be fully approached through theory alone, because the subject is not merely knowledge that can be communicated. It is recognition. A person may agree with a correct formulation and still continue to see the world in the old way.

One can write:

Abundance cannot be separated from participation.

A person may read it, nod, and continue searching for a way to receive more without changing his relation to what feeds him.

One can write:

The world already feeds the human being.

A person may agree and still wait for a separate machine, a separate solution, a separate miraculous object that will finally free him from the need to be included in a living order.

For this reason, the novel works differently. It does not announce the conclusion in advance. It creates conditions in which the old perception begins to fail.

Bread in the novel is not a symbol glued onto an idea. Bread acts. It smells, breaks, remains on a plate, is shared, seems too little or enough. Water does not merely represent life. It flows, sounds, refuses to stop for the human being, and does not explain itself. The house is not only a setting. It gradually stops being a container in which people are located and reveals itself as part of a larger living exchange.

Literary form is necessary because the object of inquiry is itself connected to perception. One cannot investigate recognition without creating an experience of recognition. One cannot investigate participation while remaining entirely in the position of an observer. One cannot investigate the living by turning it completely into a thesis.

Therefore Sampo is not written as a philosophical treatise. The internal inquiry is brought into a literary form that must remain readable, alive and emotionally concrete. The reader does not need to agree with the idea beforehand. The reader needs to enter the house, hear the sentence by the fire, feel the bread, see awkwardness, irritation, shame, care, and the gradual displacement of the question.

The novel answers its central question not through argument, but through literary form.

Bread, water, earth, house, hunger, shame, care, silence and recognition become instruments of inquiry.

The result is not a theoretical system added to the novel from outside.

The novel itself is the research form.

4. The Sampo motif as a model of abundance

Sampo is easy to mistake for a machine. This is precisely the power of the motif. It almost invites the human being into error: find it, possess it, activate it, receive from it.

A machine promises predictability. If there is a device, one can understand how it works. If it can be understood, it can be repeated. If it can be repeated, it can be owned. If it can be owned, one no longer needs to depend on gift, time, weather, other people, earth, measure or participation.

But living abundance is different.

It is not chaos, but neither is it a machine in the human sense. It does not produce by command. It requires conditions. A starter needs warmth, air, time and attention. A house needs firewood, water, hands, opening and closing, entry and exit. The earth gives, but not as a service. The forest feeds, but not according to the schedule of human appetite. Water passes by the house and does not become the property of the one who hears it.

In the novel, the movement from Sampo as thing, to Sampo as machine, and finally to Sampo as Creation shows three levels of human error and three levels of possible recognition.

First level:

Sampo as thing.

At this level, the human being searches for an object. The source seems to be located somewhere. It can be pointed to, dug up, hidden, given away, stolen or shown. The question “where?” feels natural.

Second level:

Sampo as machine.

At this level, the human being searches not only for an object, but for a mechanism. He is interested in structure, operation, recipe and reproducibility. He does not only want to find. He wants to control.

Third level:

Sampo as Creation.

At this level, the old logic breaks. The source is not in front of the human being. The human being is inside the source. Abundance is no longer a separate device, but a living system of relations, conditions, exchange and participation.

That is why the final recognition cannot be staged as victory, discovery or solution. No one lifts a lid. No one shows the mechanism. No one says: “Here it is.” Because “here it is” would still sound like a gesture toward an object.

The main change does not happen to Sampo. It happens to human sight.

5. Ownership and participation

One of the central conflicts of Sampo is the conflict between ownership and participation.

Ownership wants to separate the source from the world. It wants to say: this is mine, this is with me, this works for me, this must produce a result for me. Ownership is not always crude. Sometimes it looks like care, fear of loss, reasonable planning, a wish to preserve, or an attempt to protect. But hidden inside it is often the same dream: to receive provision without a living relation to what provides.

Participation works differently.

Participation does not mean dissolving oneself, renouncing oneself, or becoming a “good person” by instruction. It means recognizing that the living gives not outside relations, but through relations. It requires presence. Not heroic presence, not ceremonial presence, but ordinary presence: to approach, to support, to feed, to carry, to wait, to notice, not to throw away, not to spoil, not to take beyond measure.

In the novel, participation does not begin with a grand idea. It begins with the hand.

The hand can take. The hand can hold. The hand can throw away what it does not recognize. But the hand can also preserve the conditions without which the living will die. This is why ordinary actions matter so much in Sampo. They are not decoration. They are research material.

The human being wants to receive Sampo as a guarantee. But the living does not give guarantee in the form of property. It offers the possibility of participation.

Ownership asks:

How can I make this mine?

Participation asks differently:

Where will something become worse without my hand?

This difference becomes one of the book's main discoveries. Participation is not abstract morality. It is the place where something will deteriorate without you if you do not enter into relation with the living order.

For this reason, Sampo cannot be received as a reward for correct understanding. It cannot be appropriated as the result of a spiritual lesson. It can only begin to be recognized as the order inside which one already lives, and which one either serves through participation or damages through blindness.

6. The living world as the true system of abundance

In Sampo, the living world is not presented as romantic nature to be admired from a distance. It is not a postcard of the northern forest, not an ecological sermon, and not a comforting landscape.

The living world feeds, but it does not serve.

It gives berries, mushrooms, fish, water, cold air, damp moss, rot and growth at the same time. It gives not because the human being has asked, and not because the human being has deserved it. It exists as an order in which nourishment, decay, waiting, measure, death and continuation are bound together.

The human being often wants to take only the pleasant part of this order: food without dependence, warmth without labor, safety without exchange, gift without gratitude, reserve without responsibility, life without death and decay. But the living world does not divide itself into convenient fragments according to human preference.

The house in the novel becomes an intermediate form between the human being and the larger living order. At first, it may seem that the house protects people from the world. Inside the house there is warmth, bread, conversation, fire, walls, a roof, a human circle. Outside are forest, water, dampness, cold, darkness and uncertainty.

But gradually it becomes clear that the house does not live against the world, but through exchange with it. The house is not a sealed box of supplies. It depends on water, firewood, air, food, hands, care, opening, closing, arrival and departure. Its life is impossible without what lies beyond its walls.

The hidden formula of the later chapters is:

They wanted to keep the living inside the house.
But the house turned out to be inside the living.

And the final formula of the book is:

Sampo did not stand in the house.
The house stood inside it.
And no one said this aloud.

This is not merely a beautiful phrase. It is a change of scale. If the house stands inside Sampo, then Sampo cannot be an object inside the house. If the human being eats inside Sampo, then he cannot own Sampo as one owns a thing. If the world already feeds, then the central question is not how to find the source, but how to stop damaging one's relation to it.

7. What the novel discovered

The research result of Sampo cannot be reduced to a single definition. To say "Sampo is Creation" may produce a correct phrase and still lose the path through which that phrase becomes alive.

The novel discovered not only an answer, but the impossibility of the old question.

At the beginning, it seems natural for the human being to ask:

Where is Sampo?
What is it?
How does it work?
Who does it belong to?
Can it be found?
Can it be held?

These questions are not foolish. They are human. But they belong to the level of perception in which the source of abundance is imagined as an object or mechanism.

By the end of the novel, the question "where?" breaks. Not because the answer is hidden, but because the form of the question no longer corresponds to what has been seen. One cannot point to a living order as to an object. One cannot extract the system in which one stands. One cannot own what makes one's breath, food, warmth and return possible.

The novel also discovered that recognition is not instant enlightenment.

The characters do not become different people in a religious, moralistic or fairy-tale sense. They do not receive a system. They do not formulate a doctrine. They do not leave the house as initiates. Rather, they can no longer see entirely as before, but they do not yet know how to live differently.

This is more important than a beautiful ending. Real recognition often begins not with certainty, but with the impossibility of returning to one's former blindness.

The novel discovered several connected propositions:

Sampo cannot be taken as a thing.
Abundance cannot be separated from participation.
The living requires conditions, not commands.
The world feeds, but it does not have to match human appetite.
A map may bring relief, but it cannot replace a living place.
A recipe may preserve memory, but it cannot replace hands.
A mark may stop an error, but it cannot create life.
A gift is not payment, reward or proof of being right.
Participation begins where something will become worse without your hand.

All of these can be written as theses. But in the novel they were found through scenes, not announced in advance. For that reason, the main result is not a list of formulas, but a change in the way of seeing.

Sampo shows that the human being often searches for miracle as a device because he fails to recognize miracle as living order.

8. Transition to Book II: Song

Book I: Sampo completes the first major law of the cycle:

Sampo cannot be taken as a thing.

But this completion immediately opens the next law:

Song cannot be taken as sound.

If the first book investigated abundance, ownership, participation and recognition, the second must investigate sound, word, hearing, relation and the impossibility of owning song as an object.

The transition to Song does not happen through an announcement of a new theme, but through Ayla. In the epilogue she leaves with a closed instrument case and hears the water. She explains nothing. She does not begin to play. She does not pronounce a formula. Yet in her silence, the next book opens.

After Sampo, sound can no longer be merely professional material, technique, effect, or the result of a correct strike. If living abundance cannot be separated from participation, then song cannot be separated from listening, relation, measure, silence and the order in which sound arises.

The working formula of the transition is:

Book I taught recognition.
Book II must teach hearing.

Or more precisely:

Sofia learned to recognize.
Ayla must learn to hear.

In this way, Radiance ceases to be a book about one motif and becomes a cycle. Each next motif does not add a new mythological decoration, but opens another inner law.

Sampo investigates abundance.

Song investigates sound and word.

The further cycle will unfold craft, form, threshold, trauma, return, birth, forest and other modes of human participation in the living order of the world.

Conclusion

Radiance: Sampo is not an academic study of the Kalevala and not a direct retelling of the epic. It works with the Finnish / Karelian / Kalevala-related field as a living source, but it does not attempt to appropriate that source, explain it once and for all, or use it as decorative northern material.

The book asks its own literary-philosophical question: why does the human being search for a machine of abundance while standing inside a world that already feeds him?

The answer is given not in the form of theory, but in the form of a novel. For that reason, the literary form is not secondary here. It does not decorate the thought. It is the means through which the thought is born, tested and transmitted.

The concise formula of the whole inquiry is:

The human being searched for Sampo as a thing.
The human being wanted Sampo as a machine.
The human being lived inside Sampo as Creation.

And the practical formula with which the novel leaves the reader is:

Abundance cannot be separated from participation.

This note records only the map. The path itself remains in the novel.